

PIGEONS AND DOVES

This is a highly successful group of seed-eating and fruit-eating birds that are distributed almost worldwide outside the coldest regions.

After the parrots, pigeons and doves form the largest group of vegetarian tree-perching birds: the order Columbiformes. But, whereas parrots have a heavy, hooked bill for cracking large nuts, pigeons have a less robust bill for feeding on smaller seeds and grain. Some tropical groups, such as the Indo-Pacific fruit doves, are specialized fruit-eaters of the rainforest canopy.

Most birds in this order are short-legged and a few spend almost all of their time on the ground. Pigeons and doves are unusual among birds in being able to suck up water when drinking

without tilting back their head, owing to a pumping action in their food-pipe. This allows them to drink continuously, which is a particular benefit in arid environments. They can store food in their bill, and they feed their chicks on a secretion from the bill. This secretion is similar to mammalian milk.

THREATS AND EXTINCTIONS

The success of many pigeon species is due to high rates of reproduction. However, some species are threatened by humans and others have already been lost. The 17th-century demise of the dodo, a vulnerable flightless species, was the result of human impact. And the passenger pigeon, once one of North America's commonest birds, was hunted to extinction in the 1900s.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	COLUMBIFORMES
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	344

DEBATE

A MODIFIED PIGEON?

Mid-19th-century scientists placed the extinct flightless dodo from Mauritius in the pigeon order, and recent analysis indicates that it was related to the Nicobar pigeon. So the dodo was really a modified pigeon, with Indo-Pacific ancestors that might already have been flightless.

EUROPEAN TURTLE DOVE

Streptopelia turtur
F: Columbidae

With a range from Africa to Eurasia, turtle doves are small, slim relatives of *Columba* pigeons. Many, such as this western species, have distinctive neck markings.

black and white striped neck patch

26–28 cm
10–11 in

LAUGHING DOVE

Streptopelia senegalensis
F: Columbidae

Common in villages and oases in Africa and southern Asia, this turtle dove is named after its distinctive chuckling song.

25–27 cm
10–10½ in

red patch around eyes

white-speckled wings

38–43 cm
15–17 in

BROWN CUCKOO-DOVE

Macropygia amboinensis
F: Columbidae

Long-tailed *Macropygia* doves are cuckoo-like birds of Indo-Pacific rainforests. Like others, this species from the Moluccas (Indonesia), New Guinea, and Australia has many races.

26–28 cm
10–11 in

NAMAQUA DOVE

Oena capensis
F: Columbidae

This long-tailed, ground-feeding species belongs to a group of small African wood doves. Its range extends into Madagascar and Saudi Arabia.

33–38 cm
13–15 in

SPECKLED PIGEON

Columba guinea
F: Columbidae

This large African pigeon is common in open country south of the Sahara, and it often gathers around towns and villages.

32 cm
12½ in

PINK PIGEON

Nesoenas mayeri
F: Columbidae

Perhaps related to turtle doves, this rare bird is restricted to Mauritius. Its once threatened population recovered due to a successful captive-breeding programme.

38–43 cm
15–17 in

WOODPIGEON

Columba palumbus
F: Columbidae

This large W. Eurasian pigeon is commonly found in woods and farmland, and often enters parks and gardens.

31–35 cm
12–14 in

ROCK PIGEON

Columba livia
F: Columbidae

True wild pigeons inhabit cliffs and hedges. In its natural environment, this species lives in mountainous regions of Europe and Asia.

31–35 cm
12–14 in

DOMESTIC PIGEON

Columba livia
F: Columbidae

Domesticated and feral descendants of the rock pigeon are found in urban areas worldwide. These birds have variable plumage patterns.